

Spooks—It's Time For a Revelation

WILLIAM B. SCOTT/COLORADO SPRINGS

Although the U.S. spook community predicted immediate and dire consequences, disclosure of the total Fiscal 1997 intelligence budget on Oct. 15 appears to have had a negligible impact on U.S. national security. Well, surprise, surprise!

Only after the Federation of American Scientists (FAS) filed a Freedom of Information Act lawsuit did CIA director George Tenet acknowledge the \$26.6 billion of intelligence funding. The figure was hardly a revelation, although slightly lower than spook-watchers had suspected. Still, it was the first time in more than 50 years that the intelligence bureaucracy has officially admitted how much it spends. The FAS is to be congratulated for making it happen.

BUT THE ADMISSION DID NOT set a precedent. Tenet quickly slammed the door on future disclosures, worrying that they "could cause harm to the national security by showing trends over time." True to form, the CIA has refused to declassify the Fiscal 1998 budget total.

The U.S. intelligence web is pervasive, encompassing offices and agencies with nondescript titles and acronyms, pockets of the military services and front-companies that pretend to be commercial entities. But it is not unique. Many other nations support their own expensive, far-reaching intelligence apparatus. Quite a few cooperate, creating a global elite that can operate outside the checks and balances of law and oversight.

Although originally set up for good reason—protecting national interests—and staffed by dedicated people who believe deeply in what they do, some of these organizations have outlived their usefulness. They are dinosaurs that consume precious resources by perpetuating a ponderous bureaucracy.

What has the U.S. taxpayer received for "black" investments that, during the mid-1980s, ran approximately \$100 million per day, every day of the year? In the aerospace arena, the spooks point to the U-2, SR-71, F-117, B-2 bomber, intelligence-gathering and warning satellites, and a few advanced weapon systems. Not bad technology, most would agree.

But what do the secret hangars at Groom Lake, Nev.; Norton, Edwards and Beale AFBs, Calif.; and remote sites in Alaska, New Mexico and the Southeast U.S. still hide? How much was spent on ideas that yielded a handful of prototype aircraft, which were chopped-up, buried or gather dust now? Will we ever know?

SINCE THE COLD WAR ENDED, very little progress has been made in breaking down the walls of secrecy surrounding past programs. Yes, the Air Force trotted out the odd-shaped Tacit Blue "whale," but it was a 20-year-old research aircraft. They just as easily could raise the curtain on the few Mach 3 attack aircraft that apparently lurk around the British Isles, Langley AFB, Va., and Western U.S. bases with negligible effect on national security. But no way. A spook elite that stubbornly maintains they know what's best for us poor ignorant folk will never show their wares until forced to do so. Or until they see an opportunity to shine.

During a conflict or national emergency, the spooks have brought their "silver bullet" aircraft, satellites and weapons, only to be snubbed by generals who didn't have time to integrate the snazzy toys into a battle campaign. After the gulf war, senior commanders were livid, demanding to know why they were never told about these systems beforehand. Reasons were feeble, and



A "black world" secrecy mindset prevents taxpayers from learning about the small fleet of Mach 3 fighters the U.S. may be operating.

the spooks have been scrambling ever since to "show relevance."

For decades, American taxpayers were willing to fork over huge sums and never ask what protection they were receiving in return. They trusted the tight little "black world" of government agencies and contractors to do whatever was necessary. Now, that trust warrants an accounting. Spooks, it's time to open some hangar doors and ledgers; time to show what you spent, what we bought, and what you did and didn't do for us. It's time to stop complaining, "any disclosure poses dire risks to national security!" You know damn well it doesn't.

Warfighters absolutely must know what you developed, what's in the lab or prototype stages now, and what you've fielded but still hide. There are many smart generals, captains, commanders, analysts, engineers and crew chiefs who will find new ways to effectively employ your toys—or your budgets, if you insist on the traditional "trust me" approach. You may have exactly what these experts need for an application you never imagined.

SPOOKS OF ALL STRIPES, GET OUT of your cipher-locked offices and look farther afield. Ask how you can serve your nation and the international community in new ways by disclosing secrets.

One immediate benefit of your openness would be a renewed faith in government. Secrecy breeds suspicion and mistrust, fueling the flames of anti-government paranoia. Why not take the high road and disclose voluntarily?

"The intelligence agencies [must] treat the American people as their customers," Sen. J. Robert Kerrey (D-Neb.) declared on Nov. 6. "The days when intelligence was exclusively a secret activity for an elite inside the Beltway are over, and if intelligence is to retain its claim on the public's resources and rebuild the public's full respect, they ought to be over."

Spooks, don't ignore your masters anymore. Step forward and accept your nation's appreciation for your contributions, and its criticisms for your fumbles. Only then can you justify your existence and future expenditures.